The Chola Dynasty and Its Naval Power

Introduction to the Chola Dynasty

The Cholas were one of the longest-ruling and most powerful dynasties in the history of South India. Their early history goes back to the Sangam age, more than two thousand years ago, and they are mentioned in Ashoka's inscriptions as a southern kingdom. The Medieval Cholas rose to power from about 850 CE when Vijayalaya Chola captured Thanjavur, and they ruled until about 1279 CE. At the peak of their power, in the reigns of Rajaraja Chola I and Rajendra Chola I, the Chola empire included most of South India, northern Sri Lanka, the Maldives and parts of Southeast Asia, and its influence stretched to the Ganga valley. The Cholas are famous for their art, temples, bronze sculptures, literature, administration and above all their navy.

What Was the Chola Capital?

The early Chola capital was Uraiyur, near present-day Tiruchirappalli, and Pazhaiyarai, near Kumbakonam, was also an important royal city. The capital of the medieval Chola Empire was Thanjavur (Tanjore), made capital by Vijayalaya Chola and developed by Rajaraja Chola I. Around 1025 CE, Rajendra Chola I built a new capital called Gangaikondacholapuram, "the city of the Chola who conquered the Ganga", in present-day Ariyalur district, and it remained the capital for about 250 years. Kanchipuram and Madurai served as regional centres.

Rajaraja Chola I (985 to 1014 CE)

Rajaraja Chola I, also known as Arulmozhivarman, the hero of Kalki's famous Tamil novel "Ponniyin Selvan", was the real founder of the Chola empire. He defeated the Cheras, the Pandyas and the Sri Lankan kings, conquered the northern part of Sri Lanka, with Anuradhapura, and made it a Chola province, and also took over the Maldives islands. His navy, a major force, helped him to capture these islands. He built a strong and well-organised administration and carried out a land survey.

Who Built the Brihadeeswarar Temple?

The Brihadeeswarar Temple (Peruvudaiyar Kovil) in Thanjavur was built by Rajaraja Chola I. Construction started about 1003 CE and the temple was consecrated in 1010 CE. It is dedicated to Lord Shiva and is a masterpiece of Dravidian architecture, built entirely of granite, though no granite is found near Thanjavur, so the stones were transported from elsewhere. The towering vimana (tower over the sanctum) is about 66 metres (216 feet) high, one of the tallest in India at the time, and it is topped by a massive stone capstone, the kumbam, weighing roughly 80 tonnes. A giant monolithic Nandi bull, about 6 metres long, faces the sanctum. The temple's walls have frescoes and inscriptions that describe the king's gifts and the organisation of temple staff, including dancers and musicians. In 1987, UNESCO declared the Brihadeeswarar Temple a World Heritage Site as part of the "Great Living Chola Temples", which were later extended to include the Brihadisvara Temple at Gangaikondacholapuram and the Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram in 2004. The temple celebrated its 1,000th anniversary in 2010.

Rajendra Chola I and the Chola Navy

Rajendra Chola I (1014 to 1044 CE), the son of Rajaraja, raised the empire to its greatest heights. He sent his army north through Odisha to the river Ganga, defeated the Pala king Mahipala of Bengal, and brought back Ganga water in pots to his new capital, earning the title Gangaikonda Chola. He also completed the conquest of Sri Lanka.

Which Regions Did Rajendra Chola's Navy Reach?

Rajendra Chola's greatest achievement was his naval expedition to Southeast Asia, around 1025 CE. The Chola navy crossed the Bay of Bengal and attacked the powerful maritime empire of Srivijaya, which controlled the sea trade routes through the Strait of Malacca. The Chola fleet captured Kadaram (Kedah) in the Malay Peninsula and attacked several ports in Sumatra and the Malay Peninsula, and it also touched the Nicobar Islands and the coast of present-day Myanmar (Pegu) according to some sources. Earlier, the Chola navy had occupied the Maldives and Sri Lanka. The Chola navy was one of the strongest in the medieval world, and it made the Bay of Bengal in effect a "Chola lake". The expedition aimed at ending Srivijaya's control over the trade between India and China and at establishing Chola commercial and political influence. The Cholas exchanged embassies with Song China in 1015 and 1033, and Tamil trade guilds such as the Manigramam and Ayyavole traded across Southeast Asia, leaving Tamil inscriptions and cultural influence there. In July 2025, the 1,000th anniversary of Rajendra Chola's Southeast Asia expedition and the start of Gangaikondacholapuram was celebrated at the Aadi Thiruvathirai festival.

Administration and Culture

The Chola administration was highly organised. The empire was divided into provinces called mandalams, which were subdivided into valanadus, nadus and villages. Villages enjoyed local self-government through assemblies; the Uthiramerur inscriptions of about 920 CE, from the reign of Parantaka I, describe an election system by drawing lots using palm-leaf tickets in a pot, called kudavolai. Irrigation was important, with tanks and canals, and the Grand Anicut (Kallanai) across the Kaveri, built by the early Chola king Karikala in about the 2nd century CE, is still in use. Chola bronzes, especially the dancing Nataraja, are world famous. Tamil literature flourished with works such as Kamban's Ramayana (Kambaramayanam) and the Periya Puranam by Sekkizhar.

Decline

After Kulottunga I the empire weakened, and the Pandyas, Hoysalas and others rose. The Chola dynasty ended around 1279 CE when the Pandya king Jatavarman Sundara Pandya and his successor overthrew Rajendra III.

Quick Facts

- Rajaraja Chola I built the Brihadeeswarar Temple at Thanjavur, consecrated in 1010 CE.
- Rajendra Chola I's navy attacked the Srivijaya empire, including Kadaram (Kedah) and Sumatra, around 1025 CE.
- The Chola capital was Thanjavur; Rajendra I founded Gangaikondacholapuram around 1025 CE.
- The Great Living Chola Temples are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- The Cholas ruled from about 850 CE to 1279 CE.